



FIELD NOTE 002 / AFAR, ETHIOPIA

Erta Ale Volcano

A NIGHT OBSERVATION AT THE SUMMIT / AFAR, ETHIOPIA



FIG. 01 Active molten lava visible at the summit after dark. Emitted light outlines sections of the crater while the surrounding volcanic surface disappears into shadow.

On 23 April 2025, I reached the summit of Erta Ale in Ethiopia's Afar Region and observed active molten lava after dark from a position at 13°36'23"N 40°39'41"E. Erta Ale is a basaltic shield volcano within the Afar Rift Volcanic Province. Its summit caldera contains steep-sided pit craters that have repeatedly hosted lava-lake activity. During the observation, dark crust opened and re-formed, molten material rose through the surface, and incandescent fragments were thrown into the air. Local militia were present as part of the access conditions. These photographs record one night at the summit. They do not attempt to describe the volcano in its entirety, but preserve what could be seen from one position during one short field observation.

PHOTOGRAPHY, VIDEO AND FIELD NOTES / TOMMASO BRUNO / 23 APRIL 2025

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The summit crater

THE SITE

Erta Ale lies in northern Afar, within the Afar Rift Volcanic Province. The broad basaltic shield rises from the Danakil Depression and contains an elongated summit caldera with steep-sided pit craters. Long-lived lava-lake activity has been documented at the volcano for decades, although its location and intensity change over time.

After dark, the wider summit became difficult to read. The active surface instead provided its own reference points: openings in the crust, reflected light on the crater walls and the changing boundary between darker rock and exposed molten material.

SCOPE OF THE RECORD

This Field Note records a single summit observation on 23 April 2025. It documents visible volcanic activity, human presence and immediate field conditions. It is not a geological survey and includes no thermal measurements, gas data, sampling or systematic crater mapping. The locator map provides regional orientation rather than a survey of the summit.



FIG. 02 Locator map showing Erta Ale in northern Afar, Ethiopia. Field position: 13°36' 23" N 40°39' 41" E. The map provides regional orientation and does not represent a crater survey.

PLACE

Afar Region, Ethiopia

SITE

Erta Ale summit

FIELD DATE

23 April 2025

FIELD POSITION

13°36'23"N 40°39'41"E

ACCESS

Local militia present

MEDIA

Photography, video and field notes

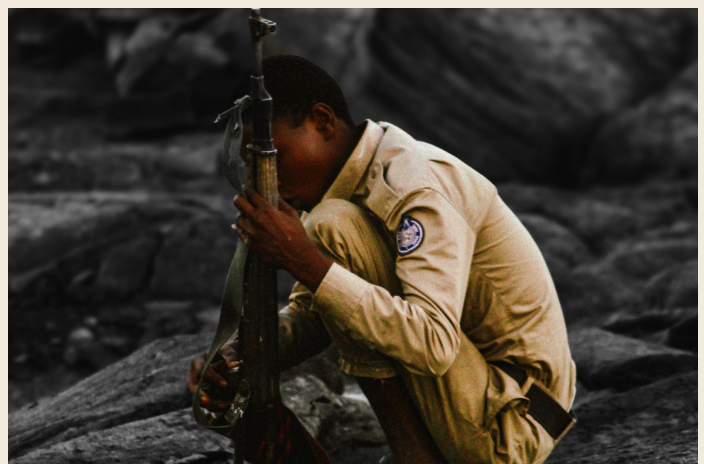


FIG. 03 A member of the local militia seated on volcanic ground near the summit observation area. Their presence formed part of the access conditions during the visit.

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Molten ground



FIG. 04 Molten material rising above the darker surface before collapsing back into the crater. The exposed form changes within seconds.



FIG. 05 A vertical surge of lava emerging from the active surface. Against the surrounding darkness, the molten material is isolated from the wider crater.



FIG. 06 Incandescent fragments thrown above the active surface as darker crust breaks and molten material is exposed.

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At the crater



FIG. 07 A figure silhouetted against rock illuminated by the active crater. Human scale becomes one of the few immediate references within the darkness.

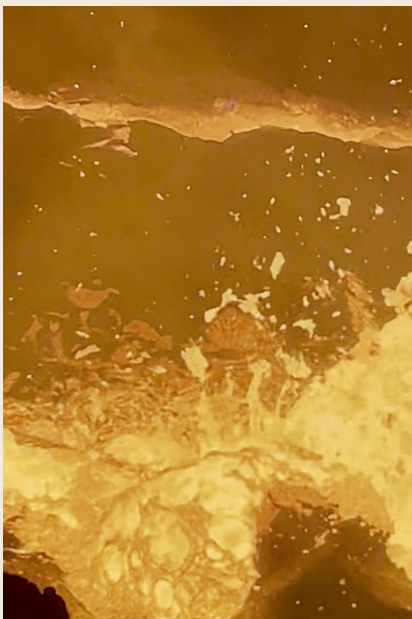


FIG. 08 Video still recording rapid movement across the molten surface. The frame preserves a condition that changed continuously during observation.



FIG. 09 Glow and rising plume above an active opening at the summit. Light from below reveals the edge of the volcanic surface.

Night into morning



FIG. 10 Low morning light above the Afar horizon following the night observation. As daylight returned, the crater's emitted light became less dominant and the wider landscape gradually re-entered view.

THE OBSERVATION

These photographs describe Erta Ale through the relationship between active material, darkness and human presence. At night, the volcano was read less as a complete landscape than as a sequence of temporary surfaces: crust forming and breaking, molten material rising beneath it, brief fountains, airborne fragments and reflected light across the surrounding rock. As morning approached, the horizon returned and the crater began to sit within a wider geography again.

SCOPE AND LIMITS

The record follows one observation made on 23 April 2025 from the recorded field position. It does not provide a complete account of activity across Erta Ale and includes no temperature measurements, gas observations, geological sampling or systematic mapping. Volcanic conditions change over time; these images should therefore be read as a dated record of what was visible during one field observation, not as a permanent description of the volcano.

SOURCES AND CREDITS

Photography, video and field notes: Tommaso Bruno. Geological context: Smithsonian Institution, Global Volcanism Program, “Erta Ale” volcano profile; Bulletin of the Global Volcanism Network reports on summit-caldera and lava-lake activity. Accessed 9 September 2026. Locator map based on recorded field coordinates; country boundaries generalized.

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